PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 09



PUNJAB ORIGIN

Kadhi Pakora

Yogurt Curry with Crispy Fritters
A Punjabi Home-Kitchen Classic

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Kadhi Pakora

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish Born from Frugal Ingenuity

Kadhi, in its many regional forms, is one of India's great examples of resourceful home cooking — a tangy, spiced yogurt-and-gram-flour gravy found in variations from Gujarat to Rajasthan to Punjab, each region shaping it according to local taste. The Punjabi version distinguishes itself with a heartier, more robustly spiced gravy and its essential addition of pakora — crisp gram flour fritters simmered directly into the curry.

Unlike its sweeter Gujarati cousin, Punjabi kadhi leans savory and tangy, built on well-fermented yogurt simmered slowly with besan until it thickens into a smooth, pourable gravy. The pakoras, typically made from the same besan batter used for the gravy itself, are fried separately and then added to simmer in the kadhi, softening slightly while still retaining a pleasant bite — a textural contrast that's central to the dish's appeal.

It's a dish that has long lived in Punjabi homes more than restaurants, associated with the kind of comforting, everyday cooking passed down through generations of mothers and grandmothers rather than professional kitchens — though it has increasingly found its way onto restaurant menus as diners have come to appreciate its distinctive tang.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish Born from Frugal Ingenuity, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A Punjabi home-kitchen staple, historically more common in family cooking than restaurant menus, though increasingly popular at restaurants today. Distinguished from Gujarati and Rajasthani kadhi by its savory, tangier profile and heartier spicing. A practical, frugal dish — built from basic pantry staples like yogurt and gram flour, transformed into something deeply comforting. Often the dish Punjabi families specifically request when visiting their mother's or grandmother's kitchen.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	45m	4	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Deep pot or kadai for frying the pakoras
- Slotted spoon
- Large, heavy-bottomed pot for the kadhi
- Whisk, for the yogurt-besan mixture
- Small pan for the tempering

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Kadhi keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days, though the pakoras soften further with time — some households consider this an improvement, as it lets them fully absorb the tangy gravy. It doesn't freeze particularly well, as the texture of both the gravy and pakoras suffers on thawing.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the pakora (fritters)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Besan (gram flour)	1 cup	120 g	1 katori
Onion, finely chopped	1 small	80 g	1 small
Green chili, finely chopped	1	1	1
Carom seeds (ajwain)	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	½ tsp	3 g	to taste
Water, as needed	½ cup approx.	120 ml approx.	½ katori approx.
Oil, for deep-frying	as needed	as needed	as needed

For the kadhi

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Plain yogurt, well-fermented and slightly sour	2 cups	480 g	2 katori
Besan (gram flour)	⅓ cup	40 g	⅓ katori
Water	4 cups	1 L	4 katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the tempering (tadka)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee or oil	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Mustard seeds	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Dried red chilies	2	2	2
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Well-fermented, slightly sour yogurt is genuinely important here — very fresh, mild yogurt won't give kadhi its characteristic tang. If your yogurt is fresh, let it sit at room temperature for a few hours, or add a small squeeze of lemon to approximate the sourness. Besan (gram flour) is widely available at Indian grocers and in the gluten-free aisle of many general supermarkets.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Pakoras

01 MAKE THE PAKORA BATTER

Mix the besan, chopped onion, green chili, ajwain, red chili powder, and salt in a bowl. Gradually add water, whisking to a thick, scoopable batter.

02 DEEP-FRY UNTIL GOLDEN

Heat oil in a deep pot to 350°F / 175°C. Drop spoonfuls of batter into the hot oil and fry until golden brown and cooked through, about 3–4 minutes, turning occasionally.



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Making the Pakoras, continued

Chef tip. pakoras destined for kadhi don't need to be perfectly crisp, since they'll soften in the gravy — focus on making sure they're fully cooked through.

03 DRAIN AND SET ASIDE

Remove with a slotted spoon and drain on paper towels. Set aside while you prepare the kadhi base.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Pakoras are ready when deeply golden brown on the outside and no longer doughy in the center when you break one open to check.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Making the Kadhi

04 WHISK THE YOGURT-BESAN BASE

In a large bowl, whisk together the yogurt and besan until completely smooth with no lumps, then gradually whisk in the water, turmeric, and salt.

05 SIMMER SLOWLY

Pour the mixture into a large pot and bring to a gentle boil, stirring frequently to prevent the besan from settling and scorching. Reduce heat and simmer for 25–30 minutes, until thickened and the raw besan taste is completely gone.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Making the Kadhi, continued



Texture indicator. kadhi is ready when it coats the back of a spoon and has lost any grainy or raw besan flavor, tasting smooth and tangy.

06 ADD THE PAKORAS

Gently add the fried pakoras to the simmering kadhi and cook for another 5–10 minutes, allowing them to soften slightly and absorb some of the tangy gravy.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Making the Kadhi, continued

07 FINISH WITH TEMPERING

Heat ghee in a small pan, add cumin and mustard seeds, letting them pop, then the dried red chilies, curry leaves, asafoetida, and red chili powder. Pour the sizzling tempering over the kadhi just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling the kadhi too vigorously, especially early on, can cause the yogurt to split. Keep it at a gentle simmer, stirring frequently, particularly in the first 10 minutes.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot over steamed rice, the classic Punjabi home-cooking combination.
- A common comfort food on days when a lighter, tangier meal is preferred over a heavier curry.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with visible pakoras and a fresh tempering poured on top just before it reaches the table.

Family Style

- A large pot ladled generously over rice for each family member, often alongside a simple vegetable side.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Tang Right

- Well-fermented, properly sour yogurt is the foundation of great kadhi — don't use very fresh, mild yogurt if you can help it.
- A long, patient simmer fully cooks out the raw besan taste — rushing this step leaves an unpleasant grainy aftertaste.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Pakoras can be fried a day ahead and refrigerated, added to the kadhi fresh when you're ready to simmer and serve.
- The kadhi base itself is best made fresh, as it doesn't hold its texture as well after freezing.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a pinch of sugar to balance an especially sour batch of yogurt — a small, commonly used adjustment that doesn't make the dish taste sweet, just better balanced.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

240 kcal	9 g	20 g	14 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Punjabi Kadhi Pakora	the hearty, savory version featured here, with fritters simmered directly into the gravy.
Sindhi Kadhi	a vegetable-forward variation without pakoras, popular in Sindhi households.
Rajasthani Kadhi	typically thinner and without pakoras, often served with plain rice or roti.

Why did my kadhi split or curdle?

Usually boiling too vigorously, especially early in the cooking process, or using very fresh yogurt. Keep the heat gentle and use properly soured yogurt.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make the pakoras less oily?

Frying at the correct temperature (350°F / 175°C) and not overcrowding the pot are the best ways to keep them from absorbing excess oil.

Can I make this without frying the pakoras?

Traditional kadhi pakora relies on fried fritters for texture, but a simpler yogurt kadhi without pakoras is also a valid, lighter alternative if you prefer to skip frying.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Kadhi	a tangy, spiced yogurt and gram flour curry.
Pakora	gram flour fritters, fried and simmered into the kadhi for texture.
Besan	gram flour, the thickening base for both the kadhi and the pakoras.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot ghee, poured over the dish to finish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Kadhi Pakora

20m	45m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Med**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

PAKORA (FRITTERS)

Besan	120 g
Onion	80 g
Green chili	1
Carom seeds	1.5 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Salt	3 g
Water	120 ml approx.
Oil	as needed

KADHI

Plain yogurt	480 g
Besan	40 g
Water	1 L
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	6 g

TEMPERING (TADKA)

Ghee or oil	30 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Mustard seeds	2 g
Dried red chilies	2
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
Asafoetida	pinch
Red chili powder	1.5 g

METHOD

01 **Make the pakora batter.** Mix the besan, chopped onion, green chili, ajwain, red chili powder, and salt in a bowl.

02 **Deep-fry until golden.** Heat oil in a deep pot to 350°F / 175°C.

03 **Drain and set aside.** Remove with a slotted spoon and drain on paper towels.

04 **Whisk the yogurt-besan base.** In a large bowl, whisk together the yogurt and besan until completely smooth with no lumps, then gradually whisk in the water, turmeric, and salt.

05 **Simmer slowly.** Pour the mixture into a large pot and bring to a gentle boil, stirring frequently to prevent the besan from settling and scorching.

06 **Add the pakoras.** Gently add the fried pakoras to the simmering kadhi and cook for another 5–10 minutes, allowing them to soften slightly and absorb some of the tangy gravy.

07 **Finish with tempering.** Heat ghee in a small pan, add cumin and mustard seeds, letting them pop, then the dried red chilies, curry leaves, asafoetida, and red chili powder.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Besan	see recipe	
☐	Green chili	1	
☐	Red chili powder	see recipe	
☐	Oil	as needed	
☐	Turmeric powder	1.5 g	
☐	Cumin seeds	4 g	
☐	Dried red chilies	2	
☐	Asafoetida	pinch	
☐	Onion	80 g	
☐	Carom seeds	1.5 g	
☐	Salt	see recipe	
☐	Plain yogurt	480 g	
☐	Ghee or oil	30 ml	
☐	Mustard seeds	2 g	
☐	Curry leaves	8–10 leaves	

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